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Edited by
Roderick S. Graham
Stephan G. Humer
Claire Seungeun Lee
Veronika Nagy

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MORAL DISAFFILIATION IN CYBER INCITEMENT TO HATRED AND VIOLENCE

A discourse semantic approach

Awni Etaywe

Introduction

Incitement to hatred and terrorist acts is a key aspect of illegal online content (Rediker, 2015) that, unlike one-to-one incitement acts, addresses a wide range of audiences and requires terrorists exploit social bonds (i.e. values) to legitimise violence and achieve their agendas (Malešević, 2019; Etaywe, 2021, 2023a). However, little is known about how terrorists utilise language to mobilise (i.e. activate) these bonds and to discursively construct a moral system in the service of positioning the inciters and incitees and regulating their moral conduct against Others. Contributing to the growing international commitment to counterterrorism, this study proposes the concept of 'disaffiliation' as a communication strategy used in incitement towards outgroups. The chapter empirically examines and showcases how terrorists use language to enact bonding and provide a moral ground for 'disaffiliation'—the process of forging value-disalignment with outgroups—while they incite hatred and violence. It contributes to the limited forensic linguistic research into the moral motivations of terrorist cyber incitement and digital deviance, examining how social 'disaffiliation' is enacted and its moral foundation activated in digital incitement texts in service of enacting moral coercion into violence. This study applies a discourse semantic approach to incitement as a social semiotic practice of 'digital deviance' (Graham & Smith, 2020), drawing on the Affiliation model as grounded in Systemic Functional Linguistics (hereafter, SFL) (explained in 'The discourse semantic approach and procedures of analysis' Section). The chapter demonstrates how the approach adopted can help us obtain empirical insights into the meta-values established in discourse to create relational and treatment/actional social networks and valuable insights into the semiotic resources whereby terrorists turn a conflict into an axiological and ideological issue, and violence into an act of care and vigilance against outgroups' immoral actions. The chapter takes a set of online texts made by the following terrorists as a case study: former al-Qaeda leader Osama bin Laden (hereafter, OBL); former ISIS leader Abu Baker al-Baghdadi (hereafter, al-Baghdadi); and the far-rightist Brenton Tarrant (hereafter, Tarrant).

Criminal investigative analysis (formerly known as criminal profiling) of an offender's actual language has been found to be useful in assessing and revealing the offender's identities and motives for committing a crime (Smith & Shuy, 2002). Such analysis can also help security and

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law enforcement agencies to better understand how terrorists communicate and how to communicatively challenge the online terrorists' content as part of the counter terrorism efforts (Brad-dock, 2019; Taylor & Bean, 2019; Etaywe, 2022b, 2023a). This chapter contributes to threat assessors' fuller understanding of the discursive nature of terrorists' inciting content, enabling new insights into the morality negotiated in digital discourse. This study contributes to cyber-forensic linguistic research – that is, the use of linguistic techniques to maximise intelligence yield and to investigate and aid in establishing evidence of social cybercrimes and their motivations, in which language data forms part of the evidence (Etaywe, 2023a, p. 909) – and to discourse analysis tools used for forensic purposes (for more, see Olsson, 2021; Shuy, 2021). The aim is to show-case how to help investigators to decode extremists' "encoded attitude"—the aggressive attitudes being construed as a result of context activation of attitudinal meaning and meaning activation of attitudinal expressions (Etaywe & Zappavigna, 2021, p. 317)—and to illuminate the pattern-ing and functioning of attitudinal meanings and moral meta-values in discourse. Additionally, the analytical strategy adds a linguistic method to the criminal investigative analysis of offenders' motives for cybercrimes, and to extremists' moral values analysis (MVA) – identifying the pre-dispositions and assumptions upon which an extremist relies to position people within relational and actional (i.e. bonds- and obligations-based) online and offline networks.

The focus of this study is on the role of evaluative, attitudinal meanings in construing an extremist moral system/order in discourse. In so doing, the chapter builds on Thompson and Hunston's (2000, pp. 6–7) argument that "[e]very act of evaluation expresses a communal value-system, and every act of evaluation goes towards building up that value-system. This value-system in turn is a component of the ideology which lies behind every text". This study also adopts the theoretical orientation that: firstly, acts of social (dis)alignment are manifest in the acts of stancetaking (Du Bois, 2007); and secondly, moral and ideological struggles within the context of terrorism are manifest in the attitudinal meanings and social values that are contested in terrorist texts and that can provide clues to the predispositions and assump-tions that inform violent actions and identity relationships (Etaywe & Zappavigna, 2021).

Literature review: terrorism, digital presence and morality

The design of the Internet and social media platforms such as Facebook and YouTube is sometimes criticised for bringing affordances that allow for driving hateful and extreme views and leading users towards more extreme content (Munn, 2020). Such affordances are exploited by extremists, be they lone wolves or organisations. Terrorists from jihadism and far-right extremism have increased their online presence for a range of purposes, including orchestrating and livestreaming terrorist attacks, recruitment, fundraising from the group's global diaspora, radicalisation and incitement to hatred and violence (Mandaville, 2007; Conway, 2012; Önnersfors, 2019). This move by terrorists to develop a strategic new media presence began with al-Qaeda and its affiliates' work towards outreaching potential fol-lowers (Reid & Chen, 2007). This has allowed terrorists to move from traditional media outlets to the new media alternative, where any Internet user can easily find, for example, a digital archive of bin Laden and al-Zawahiri's messages (see e.g. Dauber, 2009).

Other jihadist and far-right extremist groups have also established their digital presence. For example, ISIS has established its new media arms, such as al-Hayat Media Center, to enable sharing of recruitment videos and communicating via ISIS magazines (e.g. *Dabiq*, *Rumiya*, and *Inspire*) (Wignell et al., 2017). This extremist content can motivate sympathis-ers worldwide to do what they can, with whatever they have, wherever they are, whenever possible (Atran, 2015, p. 2). In addition, far-right extremists use large online forums such

as 4chan which has incubated the initial growth of the alt-right (or alternative right)—an internet-based extreme-right movement that is based in the USA but exists in different parts of the world. Unlike, for example, Twitter/X followers of extremists who are definable, 4chan provides its users with—in Anderson's (2016, p. 44) terms—"unified fields of exchange and communication" and the condition of anonymity which allows for open discussion of violence and extreme ideas without exposing the users' offline identity (Elley, 2021).

Many recent studies of the role of terrorists' use of social media in the radicalisation and recruitment processes illuminate how extremists tap into topics such as group membership, culture, ideals, and the need for self/group improvement, to intimidate opponents and encourage hatred and violence against members of outgroups (e.g. Chen et al., 2008; Youngblood, 2020; Elley, 2021). Recent studies focusing on the patterns of language used in digital extremist discourse show that the strategic use of certain meanings can provide clues to suspect extremist and aggressive identity (e.g. Etaywe & Zappavigna, 2021). This chapter adds to existing literature on the language of terrorist incitement online (e.g. Jaconelli, 2017; Tsesis, 2017) by focusing on the morality of incitement and the link between group membership, values, and patterns of evaluation.

The causes of terrorism include political, ethnonationalist and/or religious elements. Research in the field of law also emphasises that causes of terrorist acts include "intensely moral elements" that require the use of suitable analytical tools "to develop a better understanding of those elements" and to support the prosecution of illegal practices (e.g. Seto, 2002, p. 1263). This chapter will contribute to that requirement. Existing literature on the psychology of terrorism shows that an ideology or a moral system of terrorists serves to provide a set of inviolable beliefs that justify and guide behavioral mandates, and encourage followers to buttress their own identity by means such as attacking others (Borum, 2004). Bandura's (2016) work, which is based on a social cognitive theory of morality (see pp. 24–39), argues that while societies adopt standards of right and wrong, reflecting their values, and implement these standards through legal and societal orders, these moral orders are insufficient to curb an extremist's deviance and violence. Terrorists tend to, for example, provide various moral and social justifications to sanitise their acts, to enhance the construction of their worldviews and agendas, and to enable a selective disengagement from legal and societal orders depending on whom the terrorists favour or include in their social category and whom they disfavour or exclude (Bandura, 2016). Existing literature as such makes dealing with the concept of membership categorisation (e.g. Sacks, 1992) crucial to the linguistic examination of the morality of incitement acts.

This chapter adopts a functional linguistic analytic method. This method provides a linguistic account that characterises an inciter's encoded attitude and endorsed moral reasonings. It can give us "a perspective of meaning-making that is grounded in social practice and in the many varied and complex contexts in which we find ourselves", such as the terrorism contexts (May et al., 2021, p. 1). The discourse semantics-based investigation in this chapter is also informed by recent linguistic literature on the moral foundations of evaluation and acts of impoliteness (e.g. Spencer-Oatey & Kádár, 2016; Kádár, 2017; Kádár et al., 2019), specifically in terrorism context (e.g. Etaywe & Zappavigna, 2021, 2023; Etaywe, 2022a, 2022b, 2023a, 2023b).

Methodology

Data

Nine written incitement texts of terrorist public statements produced by OBL, al-Baghdadi, and Tarrant were analysed in this study, giving a representation of cyber incitement texts by members of the two most lethal transnational terrorist ideologies, the jihadist and the

Table 23.1 Overview of the dataset

Author (group)	Text code	Title/topic
Osama bin Laden (al-Qaeda)	OBL 1	A message to Iraqis in particular, and Muslims in General
	OBL 2	A message to the Muslim Ummah
	OBL 3	A message to the People of Iraq in Particular, and Muslims in General
	OBL 4	A statement on Prince Abdullah bin Abdulaziz's Initiative for Peace with Israel
	OBL 5	A message to the Pakistani people
	OBL 6	A message to the Afghan people
Abubakeral-Baghdadi (ISIS)	al-Baghdadi 1	This is what Allah and His messenger promised us
	al-Baghdadi 2	Give glad tidings to the patient
Brenton Tarrant (Far Right)	Tarrant	The Great Replacement - namely the following sections: Addresses to various groups; Introduction; General Thoughts and Potential Strategies; In Conclusion

far-rightist (Global Terrorism Index, 2020). Table 23.1 shows an overview of the texts made available online—thus not privately owned data—to address a range of audiences in a range of a variety of geographical, sociocultural, political, and ideological contexts.

For example, OBL, former al-Qaeda leader, dedicated himself to a global struggle against the USA and their allies worldwide and mainly in the Middle East. The OBL texts were communicated over 2001–2006, that is, in the period following the 9/11 attacks, and addressed Muslim communities in, for example, Iraq, Saudi Arabia, Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Palestine (see e.g. FBIS Report, 2006, for official translations of OBL's texts). The al-Baghdadi texts were produced during 2016–2018 and made available in English by ISIS's al-Hayat Media Centre and in ISIS English-language magazine *Rumiya*. The manifesto of far-right white supremacist Brenton Tarrant, 'The Great Replacement', is used in this chapter (Tarrant, 2019). The manifesto was published before Tarrant's attack on two mosques in Christchurch, New Zealand, in 2019. The manifesto communicates messages, including incitement of Christians and European men and women against groups of people such as immigrants and democrats.

The discourse semantic approach and procedures of analysis

The discourse semantic approach (see e.g. van Dijk, 1995) to online terrorist inciting texts used in this study is informed by SFL, a linguistic model that views language as a reflection of the society within which it occurs (Halliday, 1973, 1978) and that "consider[s] the social structure [which is of moral essence] as one aspect of the social system" (Halliday & Hasan, 1985, p. 4). This social semiotic perspective allows for capturing the semantic syntagmatic structures of discourse (e.g. lexical structures that signal the themes of morality) and the paradigmatic structures of discourse (e.g. pattern of attitudinal meaning). The chapter argues that these structures are underpinned by the ideologies of text authors which inform: firstly, "the attitudes and other social representations shared by members of groups [and

secondly,] the interpretation basis and contextual embeddedness of discourse and its structures” (van Dijk, 1995, p. 243).

The adopted approach allows us to focus on the functions of language which provide the motivations for language form and structure (Halliday, 1978). Within SFL, meaning is construed as a function of human experience and is encoded in language around three types of functions or meanings, termed (meta)functions: ideational meaning, interpersonal meaning and textual meaning. Of relevance to this study are (Martin, 2010, p. 12):

- Interpersonal meaning: which is for enacting social relations and expressing attitudes and building “tenor”, that is, it relates to social positioning, and interpersonal relations, affinity, power and solidarity; and
- Ideational meaning: which is for construing our experience and knowledge of the world and building “field”, i.e. it focuses on the social process, activity and our participation in life and social processes.

Since the interpersonal meaning cannot be divorced from the ideational meaning (e.g. in the act of evaluation, we always evaluate something or someone) (Halliday & Matthiessen, 2014), we can account for this association by the term coupling, specifically ‘evaluative coupling’ (Knight, 2010b). This functional approach to text, where language is “doing some job in some context” (Halliday & Hasan, 1985, p. 10), enables working out what a text is doing in terms of moralisation and legitimisation of violence, encoding interpersonal meanings and enacting interpersonal relations (e.g. exclusion). This approach to text as a “process” also enables seeing the “continuous process of [particular] semantic choice[s]” (Halliday & Hasan, 1985, p. 10), in incitement texts, as empirical evidence of: (i) how morality and social structure function as a regulator of language behaviour; and (ii) how patterns of linguistic structures reflect morality as not only “an intrapsychic matter [but also] deeply embedded in human relationships, with rights, obligations, emotional involvements, and societal networks of normative codes” (Bandura, 2016, p. 26).

The texts were examined to provide evidence of the extremists’ “appraisal signature” (Martin & White, 2005, p. 203)—i.e. the extremists’ evaluative style that is realised in the evaluative-coupling disposition (Etaywe & Zappavigna, 2021). The focus of the analysis is on the themes of morality that regulate or underpin disaffiliation, as well as on the act of disaffiliation – that is, how language is used to forge value disalignments and to influence networks of interpersonal relationships, provoke hostility, and encourage violence towards outgroups or their members. Therefore, the inciting texts were first annotated for their evaluative couplings (ideation + evaluative meaning) that realise the patterns of enacted (alternatively, tabled) bonds, and then, the moral foundations of these couplings were described, as explained next. This analysis focus satisfies two conditions set by Spencer-Oatey and Kádár (2016) for an exploration of morality and evaluations in discourse; that is, considering, firstly, which group norms are being activated or drawn on, and secondly, which foundations are used for judgements and moral evaluations.

Disaffiliation analysis: evaluative couplings realising key bonds in discourse

The approach adopted in this analysis builds on the concept of ‘affiliation’ as grounded in SFL (see e.g. Knight, 2010b), as a social semiotic process of negotiating communal identity

and a theorisation of how language users mobilise and couple attitudinal and ideational resources to form social bonds with others. However, unlike affiliation where the focus is on creating bonds and forging alignment with, for example, a group of friends, the concept of disaffiliation here focuses on de-bonding and disalignment with the outgroup—yet based on the ingroup moral system. Similar to the affiliation analysis, the disaffiliation analysis is grounded in the Appraisal framework for analysing linguistic evaluation and ideological positioning of audiences (Martin & White, 2005). The Appraisal framework, specifically the ATTITUDE system, was used to analyse and systematically account for evaluative meanings. The ATTITUDE system encompasses three simultaneously operating sub-systems (see e.g. Etaywe & Zappavigna, 2021):

- Attitude types, which include:
 - AFFECT: resources and features for expressing emotional reactions and states (e.g. hate)
 - JUDGEMENT: resources and features for construing assessments of behaviour with respect to values of social esteem (e.g. one's incapacity) and social sanction (e.g. one's veracity and propriety of their acts) in terms of social rules and regulations
 - APPRECIATION: resources for assessing the value of things, entities, events, processes and products in terms of aesthetic dimensions
- Explicitness (inscribed or invoked); and
- Polarity (positive attitude or negative attitude).

For the purpose of this study, attitude types and polarity are analysed. The main analytical unit used in the disaffiliation analysis to investigate how values are negotiated in texts are couplings of ideational and attitudinal meaning, through which audiences discursively co-identify and exclude victims. An example of an attitude-ideation coupling in the dataset is a negative attitude (shown underlined) targeted at Prince Abdullah of Saudi Arabia (the incited against, shown in bold) for collaboration with the USA on invading Iraq and using the Saudi lands for the invasion, in the following excerpt taken from OBL 2:

Before that, he [Prince Abdullah of Saudi Arabia] betrayed the two holy mosques when he allowed the Americans to enter the country of the two holy mosques under the false allegations of the need for their assistance [he/—JUDGEMENT].

This ideation-attitude coupling can be said to table (i.e. make available) a bond which we might gloss as 'Prince Abdullah is bad: traitor'. This bond serves as a moral basis for inciting the civil disobedience and the killing of Prince Abdullah, then King Abdullah of Saudi Arabia.

The dataset was annotated for ideation-attitude couplings as follows: AFFECT is dotted-underlined, JUDGEMENT underlined, APPRECIATION double-underlined, and polarity is coded as '+' for positive polarity and '-' for negative polarity. Couplings were annotated following Martin, Zappavigna et al. (2013) square brackets notation style: [ideation: <<>>/attitude: <<>>] as shown in the prior excerpt. This notation style allows for in-text annotation and suggests that ideational target and attitude are fused together to construe the values that are made available in discourse as: (i) bases for perceptions, legitimisation of violence and exploring "what is at stake when one stance is chosen over another" (Martin & White,

2005, p. 92); and as (ii) an entry point to and linguistic evidence of the social values negotiated, the social action of disaffiliation, and the positioning of outgroups as a threat. This chapter argues that, through these couplings, an inciter attempts to not only align with the incitees but also to *disalign* the ingroup's members with outgroups.

The account of collocative values in each terrorist's texts are grouped into patterns of collocating general 'our' versus 'their' ideational targets (e.g. Christianity, immigrants) with a general positive or negative value. The patterns of collocates assist in realising the overall prosodic structure resulting from this unfolding of collocative values, and providing insights into the unfolding categories of 'our' versus 'their' ideational targets and related attitudes in discourse; thus the field of a text, what or whom a text is taking a stance about, and who is, on one hand, good, victim and incited for violence, and who is, on the other hand, bad, victimiser and incited-against. In Zappavigna et al.'s (2008, p. 171) terms, focus on the characteristic use of couplings in a terrorist context allows for identifying and describing patterns of the collocative values in the paradigmatic options across metafunctions, since patterns of the same type of coupling "are likely to reoccur across a text or a set of texts under analysis", and the syntagmatic options, "since items that are coupled are likely to occur very near each other logogenetically [i.e. as unfolding in a text]".

Moral foundations analysis

The moral grounds that each terrorist tends to endorse are explored to better understand the alleged moral justifications for hostility and incited violence. The moral meta-values underpinning the couplings help us to understand how an activation of a moral foundation can invite an activation of a set of social roles or obligations and a reasoning for violence. Six moral meta-values were considered in order to sensitise us as to the moral assumptions and considerations underpinning evaluative couplings and to the relationship between morality and the disaffiliative function of incitement texts. Each meta-value was taken as a moral basis (i.e. framework) that an inciter tends to construct in their texts. The meta-values are (Haidt & Kesebir, 2010; Ståhl et al., 2016):

1. ingroup/loyalty;
2. authority/respect;
3. purity/degradation;
4. harm/care;
5. fairness/reciprocity;
6. liberty/oppression.

For example, to illustrate how values associated with ingroup/(dis)loyalty may influence the creation of evaluative couplings, consider the excerpt from OBL 2. In this excerpt, OBL negatively evaluates Prince Abdullah for an act of betrayal and loyalty to the Americans at the expense of Muslims and their (Iraqi) lands. The JUDGEMENT-based couplings realise the 'bad/treacherous Prince Abdullah' bond, and they are deployed—in Ståhl et al.'s (2016) terms—in response to signs of disloyalty and to serve the purpose of preserving a strong coalition against outgroups. Put differently, in Haugh's (2015) terms, the ingroup/loyalty meta-value underpins the interpretive and evaluative process and has a bearing on how the inciter expects the ingroup members and rulers to act.

Results and discussion

The analysis revealed the values negotiated in the act of disaffiliation and in the service of incitement, in terms of positive ATTITUDE-based couplings—as linguistic resources—used for aligning with positively charged ingroup ideational targets versus negative ATTITUDE-based couplings used for disaligning with negatively charged outgroup ideational targets. This section first reports on these findings and the key bonds realised in each terrorist's texts, beginning with an overview of key ideational targets and bonds, and then explores the moral meta-values activated in these texts.

Patterns of collocative values and key bonds

OBL, al-Baghdadi and Tarrant tend to set up an 'us versus them' dichotomy, underpinned by repeated couplings associating the outgroup's ideational targets with negative ATTITUDE while the ingroup's ideational targets are coupled with positive ATTITUDE (see Table 23.2 for a detailed account of the linguistic resources used for (dis)alignment; those used for disalignment with outgroups are in bold). For example, in OBL's texts, positive linguistic values are used in the ingroup-centred cluster to align with collocated Muslims, their Tawhid (i.e. monotheist) creed and jihad. In the outgroup-centred cluster, negative values are used to disalign with collocated America, pro-US regimes, non-Muslims and alternative approaches to jihad (e.g. democracy). In al-Baghdadi's texts positive values collocate the Sunnis Muslims, Islam, ISIS, jihad, mujahidin and martyrhood to align with them, as a cluster activated in opposition to the outgroup-centered cluster where negative values collocate with 'outsiders' with whom to disalign. These outsiders include, inter alia, Muslim Shiite and Sunni Muslims non-adherent to ISIS ideology, and America. In Tarrant's manifesto, positive values collocate, for example, with being White, hierarchy and violence with which to align. Negative values, in contrast, collocate with the following to disalign with: immigrants; state, leftists, NGOs and economic elites facilitating immigration; and anti-White terms and ideas such as multiculturalism and democracy.

Focusing on the key bonds activated in discourse, the three terrorists tend to table throughout their texts a set of key bonds at stake, meaning that their beliefs, worldviews and collocative values were relatively stable in their texts. To elaborate, OBL's tabling of the *tawhid* bonds has activated the first bond cluster: the 'good Muslims/monotheists' bond cluster in all his texts (e.g. '*to the best Ummah ever raised to humanity . . . to our Muslim Ummah*'). This activation serves to enact solidarity and inclusiveness via forging Islam as a shared identity with the incitees. OBL also tends to construct Muslims as being victimised and humiliated innocents, thus positively constructed unlike their victimisers. This construction has given rise to the second primary bond cluster, the 'victimised Muslims' bond cluster (Example 1). The 'good Muslims' and 'victimised Muslims' bond clusters are activated in opposition to the 'non-believer victimiser' bond cluster which serves in all OBL's texts to disaffiliate with the incited-against threat and the religiously different outgroups, such as the USA and their allies in the war against Iraq, as in Example 2. This bond-based 'we/they' opposition builds a text structure that is—in Maton's (2014, p. 20) terms—"condensed with axiological meanings and charged positively and negatively". OBL's texts enact *jihad* bonds whereby the 'good jihad' cluster is activated as a fourth primary cluster in all OBL's texts. This cluster legitimises and beautifies the invitation of the incitees to pursue jihad as the right path to follow, a duty, an act of heroism and the means to triumph over the non-believer victimisers (Example 3).

Table 23.2 A summary of the linguistic resources used for (dis)alignment

Extremist	Linguistic Resources	Function/Act	Ideations
OBL	Positive ATTITUDE-based couplings	Aligning with (positively charged)	Muslims Tawhid Jihad
	Negative ATTITUDE-based couplings	Disaligning with (negatively charged)	America and pro-US regimes (e.g. Israel, Saudi regime) non-Muslims alternative approaches to jihad (e.g. democracy, parliamentary elections)
Al-Baghdadi	Positive ATTITUDE-based couplings	Aligning with (positively charged)	Ahl as-Sunnah (i.e. the Sunni Muslims); Islam ISIS Jihad; mujahidin; martyrhood
	Negative ATTITUDE-based couplings	Disaligning with (negatively charged)	America; Europe; pro-US regimes and states (e.g. Saudi monarchy, King of Jordan, UAE rulers); Turkey; the Russians non-Muslims; polytheists; apostates; the <i>Rafida</i> /the <i>Magian</i> (i.e. Iran and the pro-Iranian militias); the <i>Nusayri</i> (i.e. al-Asad regime of Syria and his supporting factions)
Tarrant	Positive ATTITUDE-based couplings	Aligning with (positively charged)	Whiteness; Europeanness Fertility; (better) birthrate; popularism; violence and radicalized solutions
	Negative ATTITUDE-based couplings	Disaligning with (negatively charged)	Immigrants; Marxist; communists; Muslims; state; corporates; leftists; NGOs; economic elites Immigration; replacement; multiculturalism; democracy; Europeanization; capitalist markets; globalist culture; urbanization; industrialization; drug dealing; nihilism; consumerism; individualism

- (1) *Since about 80 years ago . . . our sons are being killed* [our sons/+ JUDGEMENT], *its [our ummah's] blood is being shed* [ummah/+ JUDGEMENT], *its sanctities are being attacked* . . . [ummah's sanctities/+ JUDGEMENT].
- (2) *They [Bush and his supporters] came out to fight Islam* under the falsifying name of 'fighting terrorism' [They/—JUDGEMENT].
- (3) *Jihad is a needed duty* . . . [jihad/+ JUDGEMENT].

Al-Baghdadi's texts, like OBL's, also tend to activate the 'good Muslims/Islam' bond cluster via forging the Sunni identity and Islam as the 'glory-bringer' bond (Example 4). The 'victimised Sunnis' bond cluster is also activated, as in Example 5 where al-Baghdadi constructs the Sunnis in Iraq as undergoing humiliation and disgrace brought about by *the Rafida* (i.e. the rejectionist), the Shiite and pro-Iran militias. While these two key bond clusters enable al-Baghdadi to enact solidarity and inclusiveness, tabling these bonds establishes a basis for activating the 'non-believer victimiser/expansionist' cluster associated with the threatening outgroups. This cluster serves to justify why to reject and exclude outgroups: they victimise the Sunnis and expand at the expense of their regions in Syria, Iraq and elsewhere (Example 5). Like OBL, the construction of 'Us' versus 'Them' within the framework of victimisation is exploited by al-Baghdadi to mobilise the victims and adherents to ISIS ideology into jihad—the fourth bond cluster. Enacting jihad bonds serves to promote jihad as being the vengeful act and the pathway to victory and defending honour and religion (Example 6).

- (4) *It was only through Islam . . . that Allah gave glory to you* [Islam/invoked + APPRECIATION].
- (5) *They [the Rafida] raid your lands under the pretext of waging war against the Islamic State [they/-JUDGEMENT], then they do not depart until they have either killed your men [they/-JUDGEMENT] and taken your women and children prisoner [they/-JUDGEMENT] or until they have driven them out [they/-JUDGEMENT].*
- (6) *O people of Ninawa . . . Beware of becoming weak in waging jihad against your enemy and repelling them [the Rafidi] [(being weak to wage jihad)/—AFFECT invoking—JUDGEMENT], for indeed, this will undo the bonds of Islam and extinguish the light of truth [this (not waging jihad)/—JUDGEMENT].*

Tarrant's messages also activate a set of bond clusters, which all imply opposing clusters. These bonds include the 'White West is best yet threatened' by replacement; and the 'good hierarchy and inequality' bond cluster. Enacting these bonds, Tarrant enacts solidarity and inclusiveness and constructs who 'We' are via forging Whiteness and Europeaness as shared master identity. The 'West is best' bonds establish a basis for the 'West' and 'the Rest' as a binary opposition in terms of power relations and civilization via alluding to the historical discourse about the West and Rest (see e.g. Turner & Kühn, 2019; van der Dussen, 2016)—see Example 7. Enacting the 'good hierarchy and inequality' bonds, Tarrant maintains his argument against values and ideas (e.g. diversity, democracy, egalitarianism) as disadvantageous ideas and concepts of White superiority as wrong (Example 8). Like OBL and al-Baghdadi's framing of violent acts, Tarrant's enacting of the 'radicalization/fight is right' bonds (Example 9) serves to propose and negotiate radical actions against those involved in the alleged 'conspiracy' of immigrants' influx targeting Whites. In an act of extreme social cohesion (namely an act of 'identity fusion') (Buhrmester et al., 2018), Tarrant urges violent actions to allegedly defend the White, win the cultural competition against the constructed threats and create a new, stronger society. Tarrant tables the 'fight is right' bonds to promote violence, civil war, killing those facilitating the mass immigration and risk-taking as a must, whereas he considers inaction, gradual change or non-revolutionary change as a defeat. These actions are prescribed so that Whites avoid becoming a minority and thus losing power; which gives rise to two key bond clusters: 'becoming minority is bad'; and 'immigrants, state and

corporate entities are anti-White', where immigrants are constructed as '*unarmed invaders*' [(immigrants)/—JUDGEMENT] and the state, leftists and democrat politicians are involved in the act of '*racial replacement*'.

- (7) *Unity, purpose, trust, traditions, nationalism and racial nationalism is what provides strength* [unity, purpose, trust . . . /+ JUDGEMENT invoking + APPRECIATION]. *Everything else is just a catchphrase* [Everything else (e.g. diversity, equality)/—APPRECIATION].
- (8) *Diversity by its very definition belies equality* [diversity/—APPRECIATION].
- (9) *Therefore, we must destabilize and discomfort society wherever possible* [to stabilize . . . /+ JUDGEMENT].

This subsection has offered insights into the key social bonds made present for negotiation in the dataset. The 'We'-oriented versus 'They'-oriented evaluative couplings tend to serve to construct an inter-group conflict as being an axiological and valuation issue, and activate clusters of key bonds. That is, these key bonds serve to function to construct social groups in discourse as oppositional, with the ingroup positioned as (culturally, racially or religiously) superior yet threatened or victimised, the outgroups (and their ideas and abstractions) positioned as a threat or victimiser, and violence and hostile acts as warranted and serving collective values and goals. Put differently, the inter-group relationships are framed in terms of who is responsible for the goings-on, and the incited actions are framed as suggested solutions—as in Tarrant's inciting killing Erdogan, in any visit to Europe, to get rid of a leader of the biggest 'enemy' ethnic and religious group: '*kill Erdogan*'. In addition, ingroup members' failure to act is thus constructed to serve to stimulate fear of the consequences of inaction and laying the "socio-psychological premise" for fear and consequently for hatred and violence (Cap, 2017, p. 1), as in Tarrant's inciting European men's violence and to accept the consequences of carrying out radical actions: '*Accept death: as it is as certain as the setting of the sun at evenfall. Only when you embrace death and the only thing you will have left to fear is inaction*'.

In order to better understand the foundations of enacted bonds, the next subsection reports and discusses the pattern of moral foundations of enacted bonds as endorsed by the three extremists in the dataset. The section also argues for the role of these foundations in justifying and morally coercing the incitees into violence; creating relational and action affiliations; and activating ingroup obligations within a common enterprise that cancels and morally disengages from the incited-against outgroups.

Moral foundations of bonding and debonding

The analysis has provided an account of six meta-values that are repeatedly endorsed by the three terrorists. These meta-values, summarised and explained in Table 23.3, belong to two main taxonomies (for a similar pragmatic categorisation of meta-values, see e.g. Etaywe, 2022a):

- '**Relational links**' meta-values: which include ingroup/(dis)loyalty, authority/(dis)respect, and purity/degradation.
- '**Intergroup or 'interpersonal treatment'**' meta-values: which include liberty/oppression, harm/care, and fairness/cheating.

Table 23.3 Summary of the meta-values in the dataset

<i>Taxonomies</i>	<i>Themes of moral meta values underpinning evaluation and (de)bonding</i>	<i>Explanation</i>
Relational links taxonomy	Ingroup/(dis)loyalty	This meta-value underpins evaluations and bonds related to obligations of group membership, virtues and practices of self-sacrifice, loyalty, and vigilance against betrayal and shifting coalitions. Evaluation here attests to the presence of expectations about the need to maintain a strong coalition against outgroups.
	Authority/(dis)respect	This meta-value underpins bonds related to social order and obligations of hierarchical social relationships and interactions. Evaluation here attests to the presence of expectations about virtues such as obedience, leadership, followership, respect for traditions, respect of legitimate authority and subversion against an authority considered illegitimate.
	Purity/degradation	This meta-value underpins bonds related to concerns about striving to live in sanctity and distant from physical and spiritual contagion. Evaluation here attests to the presence of expectations about virtues of chastity, control of desires and avoidance of the degradation of entities.
Interpersonal treatment taxonomy	Harm/care	This meta-value underpins bonds about the vulnerability of the ingroup members and the feeling of disliking their pain. Evaluation here is triggered by experiencing signs of suffering and attests to the presence of expectations about the need to care for and defend the ingroup.
	Liberty/oppression	This meta-value underpins bonds concerned with reactions and resentment felt towards those dominating 'Us' or restricting 'Our' right to freedom. Evaluation is deployed in response to hatred and actions of dominators or to signs of restricting 'Our' freedom.
	Fairness/cheating	This meta-value underpins bonds concerned with equality, and with in-kind reciprocal treatment including virtues of altruism, compassion and being considerate of the ill-treatment directed at members of the ingroup. Evaluation here attests to the presence of expectations about the need to maintain fair treatment and prevent exploitation.

Table 23.4 Summary of the frequency of use of meta-values in the dataset

Taxonomy	Moral foundations/ meta-values	Frequency			Total
		OBL	Al-Baghdadi	Tarrant	
Relational links	ingroup/(dis)loyalty	55	55	67	177
	authority/(dis)respect	23	20	14	57
	purity/degradation	1	6	15	22
Interpersonal treatment	harm/care	8	34	40	82
	liberty/oppression	25	32	2	59
	fairness/cheating	3	1	14	18

These six meta-values offer insights into how the activation of particular moral foundations draws on the ingroup members' assumptions and predispositions—or alternatively their basic moral perspective (Parvaresh, 2019)—which in turn provide semiotic clues to how certain experiences are responded to and how social roles, expectations, rights and duties are activated. These meta-values reveal that the evaluative couplings in the dataset are not “unregulated outburst[s] of aggression” (Kádár, 2017, p. 31). Instead, they follow an identifiable pattern that function to present each inciter and their incitees as deontic participants motivated by and operating within certain moral frameworks.

Despite similarity in the moral foundations activated in the incitement texts, the frequency of use of each meta-value varies (see Table 23.4). The increased frequency of use of the ingroup/(dis)loyalty meta-value (as emphasised in bold) presents this meta-value as the dominant foundation across the three terrorists' texts and as the key pedestal for polarisation and incitement to violence, as an act of respect for traditions and an act of care and vigilance against outgroup coalitions. The loyalty to ingroup meta-value is thus found to be a locus for the remaining foundations that are contingent on defining who ‘We’ are (not). In the following, each meta-value is exemplified at a time. Attention in the subsequent subsections is drawn to the evaluative couplings underpinned by each meta-value at a time.

Ingroup/(dis)loyalty

Ingroup/(dis)loyalty underpins bonds related to obligations of group membership, including virtues of self-sacrifice and vigilance against betrayal and shifting coalitions. The evaluative couplings here attest to the presence of expectations about the need to maintain a strong coalition against outgroups. To clarify how values associated with (dis)loyalty may influence the creation of evaluative couplings, consider Examples 10–12 and the JUDGEMENT-based couplings there, with a focus on structure in bold (the JUDGEMENT lexis or expressions are underlined). In Example 10, taken from OBL 2 inciting violence against regimes in Muslim majority countries, OBL negatively evaluates the governments of these countries as being *traitor*, *collaborator* and thus part of the US coalition that targets Muslims. In Example 11, taken from al-Baghdadi 1 inciting the Sunnis against their rulers, al-Baghdadi describes the rulers as practicing the lowest *forms of treachery*. In Example 12—where Tarrant incites European men and women not to pay taxes to the state that gives the Whites' money to people who *despise* Whites—Tarrant describes the act of non-payment as *a sign of racial*

loyalty while taxation is evaluated as a *theft* and the European nations are thus being ruled by non-loyal men and women.

- (10) *It is no secret that any government formed by the United States is a traitor and collaborator government like all governments in the region.*
- (11) *O Abl as-Sunna, your rulers in the region have practiced the lowest and most despicable form of treachery history has known, for they sold your issue and surrendered your affair and your land to your enemy.*
- (12) *Until our nations are run by men and women loyal to our cause[,] taxation should be considered theft, and refusal to pay taxes a sign of racial loyalty.*

As such, evaluative couplings seem to be deployed in response to signs of disloyalty and to serve the purpose of preserving a strong union. In other words, what appears to have triggered the considerations of morality in these situations is each terrorist's expectation that people of the ingroup should be vigilant of and move against disloyalty. The negative evaluative couplings concerning outgroups can best be described as "reactions to an allegedly immoral/inappropriate action" (Kádár, 2017, p. 33), the realisation of which is grounded in the inciters' and incitees' basic moral perspective. Dis/loyalty can thus underpin the interpretive and evaluative process (Haugh, 2015), and it has a bearing on how each terrorist reacts and expects the ingroup members to react to social actions. In addition, the activation of the (dis)loyalty foundation invites activation of a set of expectations such as devotion to the cause of the ingroup. However, accusing Others of the unfulfilment of these expectations leads to aggressive, negative evaluation. Drawing on this moral foundation serves to brand OBL and al-Baghdadi as loyal warriors dedicated to Muslims' coalition against Others; and so is Tarrant to his Christian and racial group.

Authority/(dis)respect

Authority/(dis)respect underlies bonds related to social order and obligations of hierarchical social relationships and interactions (see also Haidt, 2012). Evaluative couplings here attest to the presence of expectations about virtues related to leadership and followership, such as respect for traditions and legitimate authority and subversion against illegitimate leadership or authority. Put differently, social values associated with authority/(dis)respect influence how evaluative couplings are formed. Consider Examples 13–16 and the JUDGEMENT-based couplings there. In Example 13, taken from OBL 5 inciting the Pakistani people to support the Afghans in their jihad against the Americans, OBL perceives *Mullah Mohammad Omar* positively as a leader aligned with Allah's voice, while OBL and the mujahidin are seen as respectful subordinates and followers of that leader. In Example 14, taken from OBL 4 inciting disobeying and toppling Muslim countries' rulers and rejecting Prince Abdullah bin Abdulaziz's initiative for peace with Israel, Prince Abdullah is viewed negatively as someone who disrespects traditions by supporting non-Muslims against the Palestinians through *tricking* and *'false promising'* the Palestinians and *'aborting'* their uprising/jihad. In Example 15, taken from al-Baghdadi 2 inciting the Sunnis in Syria against the commanders of *Sahwa* (awakening) factions, al-Baghdadi negatively views those commanders and officers as being dishonest, deceivers of their followers, supporting *the Nusayri taghut* (i.e. the Syrian regime) and fighting with him against ISIS and the Sunnis. In Example 16, in inciting a swift takeover of European cities and decision-making institutions by pro-popularism and

white supremacy, Tarrant negatively views the politicians controlling these cities as being anti-White and thus feels they ought to be changed.

- (13) I convey glad tidings to you brothers, announcing that we are steadfast in the path of jihad . . . under the leadership of our Mujahid emir [i.e. leader], who is proud of his religion, the Commander of the faithful, Mullah Mohammad Omar.
- (14) By announcing the initiative, he [Prince Abdullah of Saudi Arabia] is following the footsteps of his father who aborted 1936 CE/1354 H Intifada with a false promise to the Palestinians from him and the English government, thus tricking the Palestinians, stopping their Intifada, and continuing the occupation until . . . Palestine was handed over to the Jews.
- (15) Therefore, O soldiers of the Sahwa factions in Syria, is it not time for you to realise what is taking place around you, and what situation your commanders and the officers of your faction are leading you to? They deceived you and seduced you with supporting ahl al-Sunna in Syria after claiming to have split away from and opposed the Nusayri taghut. But today, they reconcile with him and stand with him side by side in fighting the Khilafa State . . .
- (16) [I]t's the cities where the anti-white politicians and the NGOs make their homes.

As such, evaluative couplings are deployed in response to signs of 'illegitimate' leadership and to serve to preserve the integrity of (the 'ought to be') established hierarchies. What appears to have triggered the considerations of morality in these instances is the terrorists' expectation that authorities and leaders should work for their own particular social groups; otherwise, authority subversion should be accepted and expected. These considerations operate—in Haidt's (2012, p. 168) terms—by "look[ing] in two directions—up towards superiors [e.g. Allah, Islamic traditions, pro-White traditions] and down towards subordinates". That is, couplings appear to be in response to the perception of leaders' conduct as being a violation of the ingroup traditions and interests, which occasion the negative evaluations of disaligned leaders and reinforce the call for subordinates to align with the inciters' proposals. The evaluative couplings are thus reactions to allegedly immoral actions, which are contrary to participants' moral perspectives. The underpinning authority/(dis)respect serves to support not only OBL's and al-Baghdadi's discourse as being an echo of the concerns of Muslim countries in relation to subversion against illegitimate rulers (see e.g. Miller, 2015), but also Tarrant's discourse as echoing the White supremacists' concerns.

Purity/degradation

Purity/degradation underlies evaluative couplings related to concerns about striving to live in sanctity and distance from contagion. The evaluative couplings here attest to the presence of expectations about the conceptualisation of self (or an ingroup), body or something as an entity that should attain purity, or as a temple that should not be desecrated (for similar arguments, see e.g. Graham et al., 2011; Lai et al., 2014; Parvaresh, 2019).

Consider the JUDGEMENT-based and APPRECIATION-based couplings in Examples 17–19, where JUDGEMENT-lexis or expressions are underlined and APPRECIATION expressions are double-underlined. In Example 17, taken from OBL 4 inciting against the Saudi regime that permitted the Americans' entrance into the land of the two holy mosques, OBL draws on Muslims' perspective about protecting this land from polytheists' desecration, grounded in

his understanding of a Quranic verse—from the *At-Tawbah* (i.e. The Repentance) chapter: “O believers! Indeed, the polytheists are ‘spiritually’ impure, so they should not approach the Sacred Mosque after this year”. The same meaning is drawn on in al-Baghdadi 1, where he deploys his understanding of the prophetic saying: *Remember the final will of your prophet SAW that “there cannot exist two religions in the peninsula of the Arabs”*. In addition, al-Baghdadi activates the ‘purity’ value to incite patience and steadfastness in jihad, through presenting the suffering of some defeats as being ‘like a doctor’, and Godly acts to purify the Muslims’ souls from arrogance and transgression, which are negatively appreciated attributes, as in Example 18. Couplings in Example 19 also attest to Tarrant’s expectations about the chastity of European women and how ‘non-White scum’ (i.e. immigrants) are polluting it. The same moral theme underpins Tarrant’s evaluations elsewhere (see Example 20) to encourage the incitees to ‘isolate’ and ‘radicalize’ against the dominating culture of celebrities, pop icons, politicians and priests known for acts of *suicide* and *drug addiction*, ignorance of environmental health, or for being *pedophiles*. Purity/degradation considerations, as such, serve the alleged right to enjoy and protect sanctities and assign blame to those committing acts of desecration and pollution.

- (17) *Before that, he [Prince Abdullah of Saudi Arabia] betrayed the two holy mosques when he allowed the Americans to enter the country of the two holy mosques.*
- (18) *[I]f Allah were to always give victory to the believers over their enemies everywhere and always grant them consolidation and domination over their enemies, their souls would have transgressed and become arrogant.*
- (19) *But what few know is that Rotherham [a UK town associated with a scandal of organised child sexual abuse by immigrants] is just one of an ongoing trend of rape and molestation perpetrated by these non-white scum.*
- (20) *Suicide rates climbing year by year . . . Drug use at all levels of society, in all age groups . . . Pedophile politicians, pedophile priests and pedophile pop stars, demonstrating to all the true depravity of our age.*

What seems to have triggered the considerations of morality in these situations is the terrorists’ expectation that the ingroup entities must be protected. The negative evaluative couplings thus come in reaction to allegedly immoral actions by social actors disaligned with the ingroup. The findings support previous studies that have found notions of purity linked to Western, rightist societies and to Eastern and Muslim societies and their practices of derogation, stigmatisation and discrimination (e.g. Haidt et al., 2009; Smith et al., 2014; Parvaresh & Tayebi, 2018; Parvaresh, 2019). So far, evaluative couplings have been found to be underpinned by relational moral bases. The remaining meta-values, discussed next, focus on providing, regaining and protecting the ingroup’s rights as founded in interpersonal treatment meta-values.

Liberty/oppression

The liberty/oppression meta-value underlies bonds concerned with reactions and resentment that an inciter feels towards those dominating ‘Our’ group or restricting ‘Our’ right to *freedom*. Evaluative couplings are thus deployed—in Ståhl et al. (2016) terms—in response to hatred and actions of dominators or to signs of restricting ‘Our’ freedom, and to serve to encourage actions to preserve freedom and to come together in solidarity to topple or

overcome the oppressors. Consider the JUDGEMENT-based couplings in Examples 21–23. In Example 21, OBL deploys negative evaluations to serve to motivate ingroup members to come into solidarity, rise and accept death as a solution to be rid of the *tyranny, oppression and humiliation*, and regain *dignity* and freedom. Al-Baghdadi in Example 22 creates awareness among his incitees about those plotting and *waging war* against the Sunnis' freedom in inciting 'justified' hostility and aggression. Tarrant in Example 23 also manages awareness about the negative role of immigrants and the Marxists, viewing them as *invaders* from whom European cities should be freed.

- (21) O Ummah, Rise up and stand against . . . tyranny, oppression, aggression, humiliation and contempt, for . . . our property is not more valuable than our dignity, and death is not more difficult for us than to live in humiliation and contempt.
- (22) [H]ere is the disbelieving world today having mobilized, called out, formed coalitions and parties, and gathered all its strength, partners, allies, and awliya to wage war against Islam and its people and to plot against the believers and their religion.
- (23) It's the cities where the struggle lies, it's the cities where the invaders have massed, it's the cities where the [M]arxists have poisoned the institutions.

Evaluative couplings attest to the presence of expectations about the right to enjoy and protect freedom. The realisation of outgroups' actions as being immoral appears to be grounded in the ingroup's moral perspective of the right to protect self from restrictions on 'Our' freedom and 'Our' upper hand. Consideration of the liberty/oppression foundation is thus used to serve to promote violence as rational in reaction to the hatred and negative actions of those accused of domination.

Fairness/cheating

Fairness/cheating underpins bonds concerned with *equality*, and with in-kind reciprocal treatment including virtues of altruism, compassion and being considerate of the ill treatment directed at members of the ingroup. Evaluative couplings here attest that what appears to have triggered the considerations of morality is the presence of expectations about the need to maintain fair treatment and prevent exploitation. By reference to these considerations, a terrorist's evaluations come in response to a situation of alleged immoral actions of cheating in saying and doing and alleged inequality. Consider Examples 24–26. In Example 24, in relation to the US war on Iraq, OBL couples the US soldiers and government with negative JUDGEMENT: acts of lying concerning fighting terrorism. Hence, the evaluative couplings respond to signs of cheating and unfairness. The US soldiers are coupled with the unfair cause of fighting, making gains via illegitimate access (e.g. selling arms) and supporting evil (e.g. 'the criminal gang at the White House', 'usury takers', and 'capitalists') to access 'Our' resources (i.e. stealing 'Our' oil). Considerations of the immorality of these US actions also promote OBL as the adversary of unfair capitalism and illegitimate control over Muslims' resources—a negative view of globalisation driven by greed is also identified in Tarrant's texts to urge preservation of the resources and thrift of the White. In Example 25, al-Baghdadi also promotes ISIS as a Sunni group committed to jihad in rejection of the unfair treatment and injustices against the Sunni people. Unlike OBL and al-Baghdadi who incite violence against inequality and unfairness, Tarrant in Example 26 defends inequality and views fairness in treatment as being inappropriate in a diverse society, laying the groundwork for unfair treatment towards

people from different ethnicities and cultures. Tarrant's negative APPRECIATION-based couplings, appear to have been triggered by expectations about diversity as a factor of social dis-cohesion and about the need to maintain the superiority of the White over: 'race[s] of low intellect, low agency, muddled, muddled masses'.

- (24) *Those [US] soldiers are completely convinced of the injustice and lying of their government. They also lack a fair cause to defend. They only fight for capitalists, usury takers, and the merchants of arms and oil, including the criminal gang at the White House.*
- (25) *The Islamic State is not confined to Hajin [a small city in Syria], for the sons of the Sunnah are warriors who do not sleep in the face of injustice.*
- (26) *The more diverse a group becomes, the less equal it becomes. Diversity is anathema to equality.*

The couplings nevertheless serve to demand and promote radical acts (i) against equality and in-kind treatment, as in Tarrant's texts or (ii) against unfairness, as in OBL's call to Muslims to 'work hard against this [US led] unjust campaign'. For the jihadist terrorists, considerations of fairness/cheating constitute—in Rai and Fiske's (2011, p. 57) terms—a motive and a moral premise for the incitees to act and demand "balanced, in-kind reciprocity, equal treatment, equal say, and equal opportunity".

Harm/care

The harm/care foundation underpins bonds about the pain of the ingroup members and the feeling of disliking that pain, and vulnerability. Evaluative couplings tend to be triggered by experiencing signs of suffering, and attest to the presence of expectations about the need to care for and defend the ingroup. To clarify how values associated with harm/care may influence how evaluative couplings are formed, consider the JUDGEMENT-based couplings in Examples 27–29 (focus on structures in bold). In Example 27, in inciting suicide attacks such as those of the 9/11 attack on America and justifying them, OBL frames al-Qaeda acts within the 'care' for 'vulnerable sons, brothers and sisters' frame and in response to decades of *debasement* exercised by the Americans against Muslim majority countries. Similarly, al-Baghdadi in Example 28 draws on this moral foundation to reflect care for those jihadists in captivity in America and elsewhere. Tarrant's couplings in Example 29 appear to be influenced by his feelings of care for alleged future vulnerability and destruction of White societies caused by immigrants (especially those coming from China, Turkey and India), if not acting against them now and before their 'reaching their own zeniths of power'.

- (27) *Since about 80 years ago, our Ummah has been tasting this humiliation and debasement . . . Yet, nobody cares . . . When these [9/11 attackers] defended their vulnerable sons, brothers and sisters in Palestine and in many Islamic countries, the world at large screamed out.*
- (28) *To our brothers . . . tested with captivity: By Allah . . . we have not forgotten you nor shall we ever forget you.*
- (29) *Also, relying on this time period [2028–2038, until most of the European boomers begin to pass] for our victory holds a second major disadvantage, that being vulnerability to foreign invasion.*

The three terrorists thus tend to endorse the harm/care foundation to present themselves as 'good' action-takers and dislikers of harm targeting the ingroup, portraying themselves as allegedly compassionate violent agents. The evaluative couplings deployed serve to morally justify violence in reaction to alleged vulnerability, and to urge protecting the vulnerable 'We' group. The evaluative couplings can contribute to constructing a positive image of the terrorists, who responds in language to what they view as harmful to the ingroup.

Conclusion and further research

This chapter has contributed to the understanding of how terrorists enact moral disaffiliation as part of the social semiotic practice of incitement to hatred and violence, which is a critical social cybercrime facing the global community. The chapter has emphasised, Canning's (2014, p. 47) argument for, the usefulness of the metafunctional approach to forensic stylistics and providing valuable insights into criminal contexts, the morality of terrorism, and the ethical motives for crimes and online deviance. An extremist's appraisal signature has been found to be revelatory of opposing clusters of key bonds, enacted in discourse as collocative values. The findings reveal: (i) key social bonds at stake, realised in the extremists' appraisal signature as collocating values – i.e. axiological meanings and positively charged 'we' versus negatively charged 'they'; and (ii) inciter-incitee-victims' relationships and interpersonal treatment that are regulated and underpinned by a discursively constructed moral order of six meta-values that the extremists endorse ('ingroup/(dis)loyalty', 'authority/(dis)respect', 'purity/degradation', 'liberty/oppression', 'fairness/cheating', and 'harm/care').

Discourse meaning as constructed in cyber incitement texts has been found useful in embodying not only opinions (van Dijk, 1995) but also on-/off-line communities and their moral system. A terrorist text tends to construct—in White's (1997) terms—a model of social and moral order; that is, a model of what is normal and aberrant, beneficial and harmful, praiseworthy and blameworthy, and thus of what is (dis)approved of social actors in response towards a moral order disruption or a breach of a group's moral order. In addition, in Martin and White's (2005, p. 211) terms, the nuances of discourse semantics have offered insights into the incitement texts as being: axiologically speaking, unfolding rhetorically as an invitation to a social and actional affiliation against disaffiliative Others; and ideologically speaking, tending to unfold as moralised rationality (i.e. in a quest for 'truth') that is subjected to an extremist's "truth criteria" (van Dijk, 1998, p. 30), since they encourage the incitees to favour the ingroup and to delegitimise the outgroups.

The concept of disaffiliation and the coupling approach to disaffiliation have offered a tool whereby we view language in incitement texts as "a network of bonds and obligations" (Firth, 1964, p. 113). Evaluative couplings are found to be regulated reactions to allegedly immoral Others, a regulation that serves to view hostility as being justified and violence as legitimate. In other words, evaluative acts are found to be not only situationally constructed but also morally informed. In addition, the coupling approach has been revelatory of the linguistic resources that extremists use to manage to reverse the disdain a society may feel for a terrorist into a common enterprise against a shared enemy. This kind of cultural appropriation (e.g. van Langenhove, 2017) enables the extremists to turn violence into a communal goal (e.g. seeking justice) via the incitees' involvement in changing the world (e.g. toppling 'bad' rulers). This interpersonal influence accords with Reicher et al.'s (2008) argument that positive representation of the ingroup and negative representation of outgroups serve to make eradicating outgroups justified. In Hodge and Kress's (1988, pp. 3–4) terms,

by producing and constructing the complex moral-inciting behaviour, members of a social group can become constrained by means of linguistic structuring of “versions of reality” upon which the incited action is based and the incitees’ interpretation for the inciting text relies. The meta-values taxonomy identified can help criminal investigators: (i) to interpret what links social structure to people’s action; that is, how structures influence agents and are created through agency (see also van Langenhove, 2017); and (ii) to explore what binds inciters and incitees into certain roles, duties and obligations (see also Graham et al., 2011).

Unlike Smith et al. (2014, p. 1560) who found that binding (i.e. relational) meta-values (e.g. loyalty and respect for authority) do not “necessarily lead to in-group favoritism and outgroup derogation”, these moral foundations have been found here doing so. This means that the role of meta-values varies across discourses, contexts and users. Terrorists coming from “individualistic cultures” yet condemning their dominant cultures (e.g. Tarrant), and those coming from “sociocentric cultures” (e.g. OBL and al-Baghdadi) (Haidt, 2012, p. 30) are found using the same meta-values, which ultimately serve to enhance the terrorists’ moral regard. The similarities between the terrorists’ moral foundations could be ascribed to the similarity in the function of incitement texts and their purposes, as well as to the fact that these foundations are—in Spencer-Oatey and Kádár’s (2016) terms—universally applicable yet socio-culturally and contextually sensitive.

Finally, understanding the morality of violence and digital deviance, as well as the inherent moral appeal of extremists to potential followers, is crucial for maintaining global stability. The analytical strategy showcased in this study offers a valuable complementary method to the investigative approaches of law enforcement, intelligence and security organisations. This method can provide investigators with linguistic evidence and insights into the moral motives behind incitement and digital deviance, as well as into the social semiotic processes involved in enacting extreme forms of social (dis)affiliations, including identity fusion, discord, cancelling, and selective moral (dis)engagement.

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